

rejected France's influence. Napoleon, however, was obsessed with restoring the Roman Empire by mastering Italy and conquering Britain. However, his dynastic aspirations reflected an increasingly dictatorial character prone to errors of judgment, such as overthrowing the Bourbon dynasty in Spain and replacing it with his own dynastic successor, his brother Joseph, thus

provoking the Peninsular War—a long and disastrous campaign that raged between 1808 and 1813 and became known as “the Spanish ulcer.”

Defeat and downfall

The destruction of two French fleets by English admiral Horatio Nelson at Aboukir Bay, Egypt, in 1798, and Trafalgar off the coast of Spain in 1805 scuppered Napoleon's plans for invading Britain. However, he insisted on

Napoleonic Empire

In 1812, at the height of France's conquests, more than 44 million subjects lived within the empire, some ruled directly from Paris, some by proxy rulers.

KEY

- French territory ruled directly from Paris
- Dependent state



crippling England economically, by maintaining a maritime blockade, and it was this that eventually led to his downfall. It caused unnecessary wars against Portugal (1808–13) and Russia (1812), creating two simultaneous fronts and provoking his most disastrous defeats. These were epitomized by the humiliating retreat from Moscow in 1812, when he lost more than half a million men.

These campaigns left him vulnerable to a legacy of European resentments and military exhaustion following his defeat at Leipzig in 1813. He was finally defeated at Waterloo in 1815, by Prussia, and the Duke of Wellington's Allied army of British, Dutch, Belgians, and Germans.

IDEA

MASS CONSCRIPTION

Between 1792 and 1815, mass conscription supplied the 4 million men who fought in Napoleon's campaigns, including his first major success in Italy against the Austrians (1796–97, pictured below). In 1805 and 1812 he raised two vast armies, known as “*grandes armées*,” from across his empire to fight in his Austrian and Russian campaigns. The first had 200,000 men and the second more than 600,000. Napoleon owed much of his success to these armies. It is estimated that around a million soldiers died in creating Napoleon's empire.



AFTER

Following Napoleon's resignation in 1814, Europe's rulers met at the Congress of Vienna to carve out a new balance of power.

POST-NAPOLEONIC EUROPE

Most of the hereditary monarchies overthrown by Napoleon were restored, allowing 30 more years of reactionary rule. Indeed, both Napoleon's son and nephew (right) went on to rule France.



NAPOLÉON III

REPUBLICAN MOVEMENTS

Nationalist republican movements were quick to break out—first in Serbia, Greece, and Belgium; then, in 1848, in a wave of urban revolts that ultimately led to Italian (1861) and German (1871) unification **330–33** >>. Napoleon's fall also paved the way for Britain to become the world's leading imperial power.

NAPOLEON'S DREAM

The **unification of Europe**, started by his legacy of a new legal code and metric system of weights and measures, was realized in 1957 in the shape of the EEC (now the EU) **452–53** >>.

“History is a set of lies... people have agreed upon.”

NAPOLÉON, FROM HIS MEMOIRS, 1823